effected districts of Punjab and found that there was no sign of communal tension between Sikhs and Hindus. He also found that the policy of ruthless suppression of Sikh militancy was taking the Punjab Police nowhere. If a terrorist was killed, his place was quickly taken by another. That convinced him to follow a policy of winning hearts and minds of the local population, as it would be a better way to isolate the hard-core and Pakistan-inspired terrorists. Chaman Lal's policy of dealing with the situation as per the law eventually helped him to win the confidence of the people of Punjab and also of DGP Julio Ribeiro (March 1986–March 1988). In recognition of the services rendered by him during that period, the Government of India bestowed upon him the national award of Padma Shri on the occasion of the 1988 Republic Day.

Following Operation Black Thunder II (May 9 to 18, 1988), as per information reaching Ribeiro (by now advisor to the governor of Punjab) the general rural population had lost all respect for the 'boys' (a term used in Punjab at the time to describe the terrorists). Keeping that in view, the rural populace's feeling was that the best way to further isolate the 'boys' would be to put a stop to the cordon and search operations launched under DGP K.P.S. Gill's instructions. When this suggestion was discussed by Ribeiro with Governor S.S. Ray in the presence of Gill, the latter's policy of consolidating the gains from Black Thunder by mopping up the collaborators of terrorists, prevailed over the policy of winning hearts and minds of the rural population as suggested by Ribeiro.

During his seven months' stay in Punjab after K.P.S. Gill took over as DGP (April 1988–1990 and again from 1991 to December 1995) Lal observed that police started wielding immense power, becoming a law unto themselves. There was rampant corruption. Lawful policing was derided as a soft policy. During cordon and search operations, Punjab police used to pick up a number of young men. Only if the parents of these men paid money to the police was a case registered. Otherwise they were eliminated without any trace. To get higher rewards in some cases, the category of a captured terrorist was deliberately raised by registering false cases against him, before he was eliminated.